Your first-client business handbook

Efosa Ojomo | Austin, Texas | November 7, 2026

This is a working guide for running your technology services business as one person. Read pages 1-3 first. Then use the page that matches your next task. The initial goal is one suitable paying client, a controlled delivery, and a repeatable process.

You do not need separate departments yet. You need to perform their jobs consistently. The routines and commercial examples here are suggested starting policies, not claims about your existing operations. Dollar examples are illustrations, not your website prices. Texas setup and tax points have official references; have a Texas accountant and attorney apply them to your situation.

The whole business in one sequence

Find a suitable prospect > discuss the problem > agree a written scope > sign > collect the agreed first payment > onboard > deliver and review > obtain acceptance > collect remaining payment > hand over > offer suitable ongoing care.

Find the instructions you need

- **2:** Set up the business in Austin.
- **3:** Choose what to sell and whom to approach.
- **4:** Find your first clients and advertise.
- **5:** Respond to inquiries and run discovery calls.
- **6:** Calculate prices and write proposals.
- **7:** Put agreements and boundaries in writing.
- **8:** Invoice, collect payments, and handle overdue bills.
- **9:** Keep accounts and manage cash.
- **10:** Onboard a new client.
- **11-12:** Deliver each of your services.
- **13:** Manage delivery, changes, and problems.
- **14:** Finish well and retain clients.
- **15:** Choose tools and use your website.
- **16:** Run your weekly routine and manage capacity.
- **17:** Copy the message and document templates.
- **18:** Follow your first-month plan and use official resources.

Start today: choose one audience and one entry offer, write down ten people you can approach, and book a business setup consultation. Complete the setup checks before accepting paid work.

2. Set up the business in Austin

Do these before your first paid engagement

1. **Choose the legal business name and structure.** Discuss sole proprietorship versus a Texas LLC with a Texas attorney/accountant. An LLC involves formation and continuing obligations; it does not replace insurance or a contract. Confirm your actual business address and county; an Austin mailing address does not always mean Travis County. Follow the applicable assumed-name/DBA rules for your structure. Texas business structures.
2. **Complete the registrations your structure requires.** For an LLC, arrange formation and a registered agent. Obtain an EIN if required or appropriate for your banking and tax setup, directly through the IRS; the IRS application is free. Keep formation, EIN, and registration records together. IRS EIN.
3. **Check local requirements.** Use Austin's starting-business guidance to check your activity, location, and home-office permissions. Check your lease/HOA terms if working from home. Texas has no general business license, but activity-specific requirements can apply. Austin start-a-business guide.
4. **Separate the money.** Open a dedicated business bank account using the bank's required documents. Use it for client receipts and business expenses. Set up bookkeeping and a tax calendar.
5. **Resolve Texas sales tax before invoicing.** Website creation, hosting, and maintenance are listed as taxable data processing; 20% of data-processing charges is exempt. Have an accountant classify each offer, bundles, customer location, applicable rate, permit, and filing frequency. Automation, software, and advisory work need their own analysis. Do not assume every technology service has the same treatment. Texas taxable services, permit application.
6. **Prepare the commercial protections.** Obtain advice on professional liability/errors-and-omissions and cyber insurance appropriate to your work; have your services agreement reviewed. Prepare a W-9 for clients through a secure channel when requested.

Your output: a setup folder, business account, tax instructions for your offers, reviewed agreement, and calendar of filing dates. Do not put tax IDs in public marketing material.

3. Choose what to sell first

Your repository's current business model covers websites and custom software, product/technology management, customer support systems, and business automation, with architecture/advisory as a specialist capability. You can keep that range while making your initial sales message specific.

A practical starting focus

Starting hypothesis: Austin service businesses with a small team, an owner you can reach, and a clear website or inquiry-handling problem. This is a segment to test through conversations, not a proven market result.

Positioning sentence: "I help Austin service businesses improve their websites and the systems behind customer inquiries, with a clear project scope and optional ongoing care."

Lead with the business problem. Explain the technology after the owner understands what improves. Use your name and direct responsibility; describe your actual capacity accurately.

Use a simple offer ladder

- **Free introductory call:** 20-30 minutes to understand fit and choose a next step. Detailed designs and implementation plans are separate work.
- **First project:** a defined business website build or one defined support/automation setup. Choose the one you can demonstrate and deliver confidently.
- **Follow-on care:** website care or support/automation management with named systems, tasks, hours, and exclusions.
- **Founder work:** use a paid Product Discovery Sprint when requirements are uncertain. Quote custom engineering after scope is clear. Fractional technical product management needs defined authority, capacity, and meetings.

Write an offer card before selling

Fill in: buyer; problem; included deliverables; excluded work; client inputs; estimated duration after inputs arrive; review rounds; acceptance checks; price/cost assumptions; optional care.

Example scope: up to five agreed website pages, one inquiry form, one CMS collection, two consolidated design review rounds, launch checks, and one handover session. Copywriting, online stores, new integrations, and ongoing care require separate agreement.

Fit check: accept work you understand, can test, and can support within your available time. Refer out or involve a qualified specialist when the work exceeds that capacity.

4. Find clients and advertise yourself

Begin with conversations and evidence

1. List **20 suitable businesses** and **10 existing contacts**. Record name, business, observed problem, contact method, date approached, and next action. Keep observations factual and based on public information.
2. Prepare two useful proof pieces: a website demonstration and a simple workflow demonstration. Clearly label personal/demo projects. Show what you built, your role, and what the demonstration proves. Never invent clients, results, or testimonials.
3. Ask existing contacts for introductions. Contact a few relevant owners individually each working day. Use the message on page 17, adjusted to what you actually observed.
4. Build relationships with designers, copywriters, accountants, and small agencies whose clients need technical delivery. Explain your scope and how referrals will be handled. Obtain permission before sharing a person's details.
5. Attend one relevant local business event each week or fortnight. Ask owners how they currently handle inquiries and updates. Follow up only with an appropriate next step.

Keep marketing small and measurable

Post one useful explanation or demonstration weekly on the channel your target buyers use. Examples: "What happens after a website inquiry arrives?" or "Three checks before launching your new business website." End with one invitation to discuss that problem.

Use your business-owner page for business-owner outreach and founder page for founder outreach. Check that the live wording and contact route match the service you are offering.

Paid advertising: first establish that real conversations can turn into paid work. Then test one offer, one landing page, one audience, a fixed spend cap you can afford to lose, and inquiry tracking. Stop at the cap and review qualified leads and sales. Clicks alone do not establish success.

Commercial email to U.S. businesses is covered by CAN-SPAM too. Use accurate identity/subjects, required advertising disclosure and postal address, a clear opt-out, and honor opt-outs within the required period. Do not buy lists or bulk-send the sample message. FTC guide.

5. Handle an inquiry and run discovery

When someone contacts you

1. Reply within your stated business hours; aim for the next business day. Confirm the problem in one sentence and propose a short call.
2. Record the lead and a dated next action. Website inquiries have a repository-supported admin pipeline; manual outreach can begin in a simple prospect list.
3. Qualify before doing extensive unpaid work: Is the need clear? Is a decision-maker involved? Is there a workable budget, deadline, and access to required systems?

A 25-minute introductory call

- **Minutes 0-3:** "What made you look for help now?"
- **Minutes 3-12:** "Walk me through the process today. Where does it fail? Who uses it? How often does this happen? What does the problem cost in time or missed opportunities?"
- **Minutes 12-18:** "What outcome would make this worthwhile? Who approves it? What budget range have you allowed? What date matters, and why? What systems or sensitive data are involved?"
- **Minutes 18-23:** Summarize the problem, likely first scope, client responsibilities, and unknowns. Avoid promising delivery dates before checking capacity.
- **Minutes 23-25:** Agree the next action and date: proposal, paid discovery, more information, referral, or no fit.

After the call

Send a short written recap: problem, desired result, known constraints, information needed, and next step/date. Save notes. If the solution needs substantial investigation, offer paid discovery with defined outputs instead of silently doing free consulting.

Use the existing stages: **NEW > QUALIFIED > DISCOVERY_SCHEDULED > PROPOSAL_SENT > WON / LOST**. Move stages as events occur. Define WON internally as a signed engagement; track initial payment and readiness separately. A booking is not a sale.

Decline or narrow the work when the deadline is impossible, payment expectations are unclear, nobody owns decisions, or the work is beyond your experience. Offer a smaller first phase when appropriate.

6. Calculate a price and send a proposal

Estimate the full job

List discovery, meetings, design/configuration, implementation, testing, documentation, revisions, launch, and handover. Estimate hours for each. Add a visible internal allowance for uncertainty. Include approved direct costs and identify recurring client subscriptions separately.

Internal rate check: (monthly owner compensation target + business overhead + business reserve contribution) divided by realistic billable hours. Owner compensation here is a planning target; it is not an instruction to run payroll. Ask your accountant how you should actually pay yourself.

Illustration: $4,000 compensation target + $500 overhead + $500 reserve, divided by 60 billable hours = about $83.33/hour before your personal tax planning. A 30-hour scope plus six hours of contingency at $85/hour is $3,060 before direct costs and applicable tax. This is arithmetic for planning, not a recommended market price or a profit guarantee.

Check whether the scope is worth that price to the buyer and viable for you. If the budget is too low, reduce deliverables, phase the project, or decline. Avoid discounting an unchanged scope below a sustainable price.

Choose a commercial model

- **Fixed fee:** clear deliverables, controlled reviews, and acceptance tests.
- **Milestones:** larger engineering projects with separate deliverables and payment gates.
- **Paid discovery:** uncertainty must be reduced before a build quote.
- **Monthly allocation:** defined ongoing tasks, capacity, hours, and overflow approval.

Your proposal should answer

What problem are we solving? What will be delivered? What is excluded? Who provides content/access and by when? How are reviews and acceptance handled? What is the schedule and dependency on inputs? What does it cost, when is payment due, and which subscriptions/taxes are separate? What happens after delivery?

Give the quote an expiry date and state that the start date is confirmed after signing, agreed payment, required inputs, and capacity confirmation. Schedule a proposal discussion. Follow up on the agreed date, then close the loop rather than chasing indefinitely.

7. Put the working agreement in writing

Proposal: explains the offer. **Services agreement:** sets the relationship's rules. **Statement of Work (SOW):** defines this particular project. An attorney-reviewed combined agreement/SOW can be simpler for a small engagement.

Fill these fields for every engagement

- Legal parties, named approver, business contacts, effective date, and signatures.
- Deliverables with quantities: pages, workflows, integrations, workshops, or systems.
- Exclusions and client responsibilities, including licensed content and access.
- Timeline, dependencies, review deadlines, and what client delays do to scheduling.
- Fees, currency, applicable tax, invoicing milestones, and third-party costs.
- Review rounds, acceptance criteria, defect handling, and change-request process.
- Confidentiality, approved data handling, subcontractors, and any required data terms.
- Ownership/licensing of deliverables, pre-existing tools, third-party components, and handover timing.
- Termination, cancellation/refunds, payment disputes, liability, and dispute handling.
- Post-delivery support period, if included, and separate ongoing-care terms.

Have the attorney resolve enforceability and suitable wording. These are preparation prompts, not a contract ready for signature.

Make ongoing care especially clear

Example for discussion: one named website; four hours monthly across agreed maintenance/content tasks, reporting, and meetings; Monday-Friday, 9am-5pm Central, excluding listed holidays; initial acknowledgment by the next business day; additional work quoted before starting.

Specify whether unused time expires or rolls over, what counts toward time, overage approval, notice to end the plan, and emergency handling. The example response target is an acknowledgment, not a guaranteed repair time. Use only service hours and targets you can reliably meet.

No unlimited revisions, unlimited development, human support-agent staffing, or 24-hour coverage is implied. Ask before using a client's logo, testimonial, screenshots, or project details publicly. Keep marketing permission separate from delivery acceptance.

8. Invoice and receive payment

A practical payment flow

1. Complete the provider's business verification and bank connection. Confirm support for your business/country, fees, payout timing, and enabled payment methods.
2. Issue a numbered invoice linked to the signed SOW. Include your legal billing details, client billing contact, service/milestone, currency, subtotal, approved tax treatment, total, due date, and payment instructions.
3. Send a hosted payment page or verified bank-payment instructions. Stripe offers hosted invoice pages with payment, invoice, and receipt functions without building checkout into your website. Stripe documentation.
4. Confirm payment inside the provider/bank, not from a screenshot. Record the invoice as paid, account for processing fees, and send confirmation. Match the later payout to the bank deposit.

Suggested terms to agree before signing

For a small fixed project, consider **50% before work and 50% after acceptance, before the agreed final handover**. For larger work, use smaller deliverable-based milestones. Monthly care can be invoiced before the service period, with no automatic debit unless separately authorized. These are negotiable policies, not legal rules. Agree cancellation/refund treatment and any client procurement constraints in advance.

If a payment is late

On the next business day after the due date, send a polite reminder with the invoice link and ask whether billing details need correction. If still unresolved, contact the billing person, agree a documented next step, and follow the agreement's notice/pause process for future work. Apply late fees only when contractually agreed and legally permitted. Do not disable an existing live service to force payment.

If the client disputes a charge

Ask which deliverable or invoice line is disputed. Compare it with the signed scope and acceptance record; agree a correction or documented settlement if appropriate. Save correspondence and meet the payment provider's dispute deadlines. Verify changed bank details through a known contact channel.

9. Keep accounts and control cash

Bookkeeping means recording what happened to the money. **Cash flow** means knowing whether money will be available when bills fall due. **Profit** and the bank balance are different: deposits may fund unfinished work, tax may be owed, and invoices may remain unpaid.

Every Friday: 30 minutes

1. Match invoices, payments, provider fees, refunds, expenses, and bank activity. If a client pays $1,000 and a processor deducts $30, record the gross receipt and $30 fee; do not count the later bank payout as another sale.
2. Attach each receipt and record its business purpose. Separate owner contributions and withdrawals from client sales and operating expenses. Have the accountant set the correct categories and accounting method. IRS recordkeeping.
3. List unpaid invoices and your next action. Reserve amounts for tax using the accountant's guidance. Keep collected sales tax out of spendable operating cash.
4. Update a simple forecast: opening available cash + expected collections - planned payments = projected closing cash. Use realistic collection dates; an unsigned proposal is not cash.

Every month: review with yourself or your bookkeeper

Check income, direct project costs, overhead, outstanding invoices, cash commitments, tax reserves, and whether completed jobs paid adequately for the hours spent. Compare estimates with actual hours. Cancel unused subscriptions.

Example: $3,000 cash collected - $300 project costs - $250 overhead = $2,450 cash left from those movements, before taxes, owner withdrawals, other commitments, and work still owed. That is not a statement of taxable profit.

Put these dates on the calendar

Federal income/self-employment tax estimates may apply. Get your actual schedule from an accountant. For Texas entities subject to franchise reporting, owing no franchise tax can still leave an information-report obligation; applicable exemptions differ. Do not rely on an old "No Tax Due" form. IRS estimates, Texas filing requirements.

Accountant brief: "Please classify my offers for Texas sales tax, set up bookkeeping and owner payments, confirm federal/state filings, and tell me what to reserve and when to pay."

10. Onboard the client

Start only when the engagement is ready

Confirm signed agreement/SOW, agreed initial payment, available delivery slot, named approver, and required first inputs. Send a welcome email with the kickoff date, immediate actions, communication channel, and initial milestone.

Create one client folder

Use a private, access-controlled folder with these sections: **01 Agreement / 02 Discovery / 03 Client Inputs / 04 Delivery / 05 Reviews / 06 Finance / 07 Handover**. Keep your internal margins and unrelated client material outside the shared folder. Store passwords in a password manager, not these documents.

Run a 30-45 minute kickoff

1. Restate the goal and what is included/excluded.
2. Confirm who can approve scope, costs, content, and launch.
3. Walk through milestones, input dates, and the review process.
4. Agree where feedback goes and how quickly each party will respond.
5. Confirm accounts, permissions, data sensitivity, and backup needs.
6. Define a measurable baseline where possible: inquiry routing errors, manual steps, or current process time. Record observations without promising a specific improvement.
7. Summarize actions with an owner and due date; send the recap.

Collect the right inputs

- **Website:** approved content, brand assets, domain/DNS access by invitation, content owner, form destination, and required legal/privacy text supplied or approved by the client.
- **Support/automation:** current process, account owners, sample test data, permitted actions, exception/escalation owner, volume, and subscription budget.
- **Product/software:** business owner, users, requirements, existing repository access, known constraints, and acceptance examples.

Create critical subscriptions and assets in the client's ownership where practical, with the client paying vendors directly. Request an individual collaborator account with the least access needed; avoid shared master logins. Record who owns domains, hosting, repository, data, billing, and recovery. Confirm all recurring costs before purchasing.

Your output: a kickoff recap, delivery board, access/ownership list, and first milestone everyone understands.

11. Deliver websites, support systems, and automation

Business website build

Get: page list, content, brand assets, domain owner, form destination. **Do:** agree sitemap > approve one design direction > build on a private preview > gather consolidated feedback within agreed rounds > test > obtain launch approval > launch and train.

Acceptance: agreed pages display on mobile/desktop; navigation works; the inquiry form validates and reaches its intended destination; authorized people can update agreed content; domain/HTTPS and agreed analytics function. Document accessibility, privacy, search, and performance requirements in scope rather than implying unspecified guarantees. **Hand over:** account ownership, editing instructions, renewal list, backup/restore instructions, and known limitations.

Customer support system setup

Get: channels, team members, frequent questions, escalation rules, service hours. **Do:** agree the ticket lifecycle > configure inbox/routing > draft approved knowledge articles > test with the team > train and hand over.

Acceptance: test inquiries become tickets; each reaches a named owner; acknowledgments and escalations work; restricted information is not exposed. Test an unanswered question and human handoff if a chatbot is included. The client's people answer customers unless a separate staffing service is expressly agreed. **Hand over:** routing map, admin guide, team instructions, and unresolved limitations.

Business workflow automation

Get: the exact trigger, fields, systems, frequency, allowed actions, and exception owner. **Do:** map the manual process > agree one workflow > build with test data > test failure cases > obtain approval > enable gradually.

Acceptance: test a normal event, duplicate, missing field, expired access, and unavailable destination; confirm retry behavior cannot repeat a harmful action. Define alerts and a manual fallback. **Hand over:** workflow map, account owner, usage limits, disable/restart steps, and troubleshooting guide.

Common rule: do not start production writes or send customer messages until the client has approved that behavior. If AI is involved, agree allowed data, limits, human review, and escalation. Keep early work away from sensitive or regulated uses you cannot confidently support.

12. Deliver discovery, engineering, and monthly work

Product Discovery Sprint

Get: problem, target users, constraints, stakeholder access, available evidence. **Do:** agree workshop/questions > review evidence > define user flows and options > prioritize the smallest useful scope > review feasibility/risks > present recommendations.

Acceptance: the agreed findings, requirements, prioritized MVP, assumptions, and delivery roadmap are supplied and reviewed. Clarify that discovery reduces uncertainty; it does not guarantee a fixed implementation cost before estimation. **Hand over:** decision log and editable roadmap. Quote the build separately.

Custom software engineering

Get: approved scope, repository/environment access, data rules, and approver. **Do:** agree architecture and milestones > build in small reviewable increments > test in staging > demonstrate each milestone > obtain acceptance > approve release and rollback plan > deploy within scope > hand over.

Acceptance: written user scenarios pass; access controls and agreed integrations work; known defects/limitations are documented; deployment and recovery instructions exist. Keep production secrets out of the repository. Avoid committing to an entire uncertain product as one loosely defined fixed-price job.

Website care and support/automation management

First inventory and assess any inherited system. Do not accept maintenance responsibility for an unknown setup without checking access, health, backups, and dependencies. Each month: agree priorities > monitor/check the named systems > complete covered tasks > record time > report changes, incidents, capacity used, and next actions. Test restore capability at the agreed interval. New features/workflows require approval and additional scope.

Fractional technical product management

Agree monthly capacity, meetings, stakeholders, decision authority, and expected outputs. Review roadmap and backlog; write acceptance criteria; coordinate engineering; surface risks and decisions; give a concise monthly delivery review. Do not imply responsibility for code delivery or team staffing unless included.

Specialist architecture/advisory

Define the decision to be supported, systems reviewed, information available, and output: for example an options memo and recommendation workshop. Record assumptions and trade-offs. Implementation, certification, and security auditing are separate unless specifically qualified and scoped.

13. Manage delivery and difficult situations

Keep one delivery board

Use five columns: **To do / Doing / Waiting on client / Ready for review / Done**. Every task has an owner, due date, scope reference, and acceptance check. Keep work in progress small. Save decisions in writing after calls.

Send one weekly update

Use: **Completed / Next / Decisions needed / Risks / Budget or allocation used**. Ask for a single consolidated response from the named approver by a specific date. Flag a likely delay early with options and a revised plan.

When someone asks for "one small extra"

1. Compare the request with the SOW.
2. If included, schedule it within the existing commitment.
3. If outside scope, describe the addition and its fee/time effect.
4. Obtain written approval through the agreed change process before starting.

Say: "I can add that. It is outside the agreed scope. I will send the additional cost and schedule impact so you can approve it or keep the current plan."

When the client is late or unhappy

For missing content/access, record the dependency, send a clear request/date, and apply the agreed rescheduling process. Do not silently absorb the delay. For dissatisfaction, ask what failed against the agreed requirement. Correct an in-scope defect; price a changed requirement separately. Document the agreed remedy and review date.

When a live system has a serious issue

Triage impact and stop the harmful action if authorized and safe. Preserve relevant evidence, contact the client owner, and use the agreed rollback/manual fallback. Restore service before undertaking unrelated improvements. For a possible data breach, involve qualified incident/legal help and determine applicable notification duties; do not guess deadlines. Afterwards record what happened, impact, fix, and prevention.

When work ends early

Follow the written termination process. Calculate completed/committed work and any refund under the agreement; provide the agreed handover, revoke access appropriately, and record outstanding items. Keep the communication factual. Do not erase client assets or lock a client out of their existing systems.

14. Finish well and retain clients

Close the project deliberately

1. Run the acceptance checklist with the client and log any exceptions.
2. Obtain the agreed written acceptance. Confirm any limited defect-support window and how to report problems. New requirements remain new scope.
3. Issue the final invoice under the agreed payment gate. Complete final handover at the contractually agreed time.
4. Provide the owner/account list, repository or assets as agreed, operating instructions, vendor renewals, training, known limitations, and support contacts.
5. Confirm backups and recovery ownership. Remove access you no longer need and apply the agreed data-retention/deletion schedule.

Offer useful ongoing care

At handover, explain the actual ongoing tasks: platform updates, backup checks, workflow errors, content updates, or periodic product priorities. Offer a defined monthly plan only when those tasks exist and you have capacity. Explain what happens if the client chooses to manage the system themselves.

A simple retention rhythm

- **About one week after launch:** ask whether the team can use the system and whether there are defects within the agreed support period.
- **At about 30 days:** review the original problem and available evidence. Ask what remains difficult.
- **Monthly for care clients:** show work completed, incidents, usage/capacity, costs where relevant, and next priorities.
- **Before renewal:** confirm continued need, scope, price, capacity, and cancellation terms. Obtain approval for changes. Do not assume automatic billing.

Ask: "Is this making the agreed task easier? What should we keep, change, or stop?" Record the answer and follow through. Avoid creating unnecessary features just to retain a client.

Ask for proof and referrals respectfully

After a positive result, request an honest testimonial and permission for specific public uses. Ask whether the client knows another owner facing a similar problem. If publishing a case study, verify every metric and describe your actual role; get approval before disclosing names, screenshots, or nonpublic information.

Your output: paid/closed project record, complete handover, a dated follow-up, and either a separate care agreement or a clear end to your obligations.

15. Use a small set of tools

Start with one tool for each real job

- **Email, meetings, documents:** Google Workspace is a practical option for business email, calendar, calls, and shared files. Use an existing equivalent if it already meets your needs. Official product.
- **Leads:** your site's Project Inquiries module for website leads; a small prospect list for manual outreach. Record next action/date in notes and your calendar. Add a dedicated CRM only when follow-ups become hard to manage.
- **Projects:** start with one simple task board and shared project folder. A document checklist is sufficient for the first small job.
- **Invoices/payments:** consider Stripe-hosted invoices if eligible, with bookkeeping reconciliation. You do not need to code checkout first. Official documentation.
- **Books:** have your Texas accountant select/configure one accounting system. Zoho Books is one candidate for invoices, expenses, banking, and reports; confirm the country edition and tax setup. Avoid issuing duplicate invoices in two tools. Official product.
- **Credentials:** use a password manager such as Bitwarden, unique logins, MFA, and recovery codes. Keep client access separated. Official product.
- **Delivery tools:** prefer the client's existing system when suitable. Make is a candidate for integrations; Freshdesk for ticketing. Choose after checking workflow needs, data handling, limits, and client budget. Make, Freshdesk.

Check current pricing, eligibility, and required features before subscribing. These are options, not a requirement to buy every tool. Use client-owned subscriptions; agree who pays and what happens at termination.

Activate and verify your existing website

Repository review shows CMS offer/service editors, lead stages/notes, contact-form storage and email code, and a booking page using a configured calendar URL. This is code evidence, not a live production test.

Before outreach: sign in via `/admin/login`; review published services and `/admin/packages`; check both customer paths; submit a test inquiry with your own details; confirm it appears in `/admin/leads` and check owner/customer emails; book and cancel a test meeting. Confirm real storage and notifications work outside demo mode. Use external invoices initially. The CMS does not replace accounting, contracts, or delivery tracking.

16. Run your departments as weekly routines

You are the owner of these jobs

- **Sales/marketing:** find suitable prospects, run calls, write proposals, and follow up.
- **Operations/delivery:** plan capacity, produce work, test, report, and hand over.
- **Accounts/finance:** invoice, collect, record expenses, reconcile, and plan cash/tax.
- **Client success:** communicate, train, review outcomes, and renew suitable care.
- **Administration/security:** maintain agreements, filings, access, backups, and vendor records.

You do not need to hire someone for every line. Put each job on the calendar. Use a bookkeeper, accountant, or attorney for the work requiring their expertise.

A routine you can actually follow

Daily, 20-30 minutes: check leads and client messages; review today's promises; choose the most important delivery task; update next actions and log time.

Monday, 45 minutes: review pipeline, delivery milestones, outstanding inputs, and capacity. Reserve time for prospecting, client reviews, and administration.

During the week: protect delivery blocks; keep a small recurring outreach block even when busy. Send the weekly client update on the same day each week.

Friday, 60 minutes: reconcile money; send payment follow-ups; review hours versus estimates; update the cash forecast; back up/export critical business records; plan next week.

Monthly, 60-90 minutes: review finances, marketing sources, subscription costs, care reports, upcoming renewals, and filing dates.

Control capacity before selling more

Illustration: if you have 20 business hours/week, reserve six for sales/admin and three for uncertainty; that leaves eleven planned delivery hours. A 33-hour project needs about three weeks of delivery capacity, plus client-review dependencies. Budget retainers and meetings inside that capacity. Begin with one main delivery project if you are unsure of your pace.

Keep a tiny owner dashboard

Track new qualified leads, calls, proposals, signed clients, cash collected, overdue invoices, committed delivery hours, and retained clients. Record each lead's source. Low replies suggest audience/message problems; calls without sales suggest fit, proof, scope, or pricing issues. Improve one thing at a time.

17. Copy these working templates

Warm introduction request

"Hi [Name], I am taking on projects helping [type of business] with [specific problem]. A typical first project is [clear deliverable]. If someone you know is dealing with this, would you be comfortable introducing us? Here is a relevant demonstration: [link]."

For direct commercial email, add the required identity, postal address, advertising disclosure, and opt-out, and follow the FTC guidance on page 4. A personal message template does not itself establish compliance.

After a discovery call

"Thanks, [Name]. My understanding is that [problem] is causing [effect]. The desired result is [outcome]. We discussed [first scope], with [constraints]. I need [inputs] before I can confirm the proposal. Next action: [person/action/date]. Please correct anything I misunderstood."

One-page scope worksheet

Client/approver: [legal name/contact]. **Goal:** [business problem]. **Deliverables:** [countable list]. **Acceptance:** [test for each deliverable]. **Excluded:** [list]. **Client inputs/dates:** [list]. **Milestones:** [deliverable/date/payment]. **Price/currency/tax:** [amount/treatment]. **Vendor costs:** [payer/estimate]. **Reviews:** [rounds/deadline]. **Handover/support:** [items/window]. **Agreement reference/approval:** [reference/signatures]. Use with your reviewed agreement, not as a substitute for it.

Weekly client update

"Completed: [items]. Next: [items/date]. Needed from you: [decision/input/date]. Risks: [issue, effect, proposed action]. Scope/allocation: [status/hours used]. Next review: [date]."

Payment reminder

"Hi [Name], invoice [number] for [amount/currency], due [date], is still showing as unpaid. Here is the invoice link: [link]. Could you confirm the expected payment date, or let me know if your billing team needs anything? Thank you."

Change request / acceptance / follow-up

Change: [request]; [reason outside scope]; [added fee/tax]; [schedule effect]; [approval/date].

Acceptance: "Please confirm whether [deliverable] meets the agreed checks at [reference], or list the checks that remain unmet by [agreed review date]."

30-day follow-up: "How is [system] working for your team? Is [original problem] improving? Are there any difficulties using or maintaining it? We can review the evidence and agree whether any further work is useful."

18. Your first 30 days

Week 1: become ready to operate

Complete the Austin/Texas setup checks, or track each open item with its owner/date. Resolve tax treatment and payment setup before invoicing. Prepare your agreement/SOW, invoice format, client-folder template, lead list, and delivery checklist. Choose one audience and entry offer. Test the website's inquiry and booking routes end to end.

Week 2: start useful conversations

Prepare two honest demonstrations. Ask ten contacts for relevant introductions and begin individual outreach to suitable businesses. Attend one relevant local event. Practice the discovery questions and record every next action. Do not spend the week repeatedly redesigning your own website.

Week 3: turn fit into a defined engagement

Run calls; send written recaps. Propose a small project or paid discovery only when it fits the need. Review proposals with prospects. If a client signs, confirm initial payment, inputs, and capacity before kickoff. If nobody signs, review objections and adjust the offer or audience rather than treating an activity target as a guarantee.

Week 4: deliver carefully or improve the pipeline

For a signed client, complete the first reviewable milestone, send an update, track hours, and reconcile payment. If still prospecting, examine who replied, which problems recurred, and which proof was missing; improve one variable and continue. Review the month's cash, commitments, and lessons.

Official help and source notes

This handbook was prepared from your repository's current business-model documentation, default offer/service files, contact action, booking page, and lead schema/UI. Saved CMS content can differ. Live production services and your legal/business registrations were not verified.

For Austin setup and local assistance, start with the City of Austin business guide. Ask for help with the business plan, requirements, and available advising.

Use the linked official references beside the relevant instructions: Texas Secretary of State for structure/DBA; IRS for EIN, records, and estimated tax; Texas Comptroller for sales-tax classification, permits, and franchise filings; FTC for commercial email; vendor documentation for tool capabilities. Guidance was checked November 7, 2026; verify current rules and costs when acting. Templates and operating routines are suggested practices, not official requirements.

Your first success: a client whose problem you understand, an agreed scope, a payment recorded correctly, work accepted, and a clear next step. Repeat that process and improve it after each engagement.